PROPERTY PORTFOLIO AND BUSINESS OPERATIONS

NBAC Business Turnaround and Strategic Growth

Rebuilding business infrastructure, restoring rental properties, and creating sustainable growth across a Pittsburgh portfolio.

National Builders and Acceptance Corporation (NBAC), Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania
Office Manager, January 2017 to April 2021

Executive overview

I joined National Builders and Acceptance Corporation (NBAC) in January 2017 as Business Office Manager, initially responsible for organizing office operations, implementing QuickBooks, managing payroll and accounts payable, and supporting property management.

NBAC was an established company that Neal Scoratow had recently inherited. Neal also owned and operated NealCo, a smaller, separate rental property business where he had successfully renovated distressed properties and developed desirable rental housing. However, NBAC presented a much larger challenge. Its portfolio included more than 100 rental units throughout Pittsburgh, with over half vacant and many requiring extensive renovations. The company also lacked the financial controls, administrative processes, staffing infrastructure, and property management systems necessary to operate efficiently.

Neal had a clear vision for NBAC. He wanted to provide safe, attractive, well-maintained housing that he would be comfortable living in himself. While he brought property renovation experience and a genuine commitment to tenant satisfaction, he recognized the need for stronger business operations and a coordinated strategy to restore the portfolio's financial performance.

Recognizing my capabilities, Neal entrusted me with responsibilities extending well beyond my original position. We developed a collaborative working relationship in which I contributed financial planning, operational management, business systems development, marketing strategies, and organizational improvements to help execute his vision.

Working alongside Neal, our maintenance manager Bill, employees, and contractors, I helped lead a comprehensive business turnaround. By the end of 2019, actual rental revenue had doubled. By April 2021, the portfolio had achieved full occupancy, with every remaining unit rented under a one-year lease. The transformation also strengthened the company's financial stability, operational efficiency, workforce practices, and reputation among tenants.

Results at a glance

100% growth in rent collected. Actual rental revenue doubled between the start of 2017 and the end of 2019.

Full occupancy at departure. By April 2021, all retained rental units were occupied under one-year leases.

Nearly complete portfolio renewal. All retained properties except two occupied by long-term tenants had been remodeled, renovated, or updated.

A formal operating workforce. The business grew from two employees to approximately 20, supported by roughly 10 recurring specialty contractors.

Starting conditions

Before my arrival, finances were tracked primarily with a ledger, checkbook, and basic rental payment spreadsheet. Personnel and contractor records were incomplete. Independent contractors were sometimes managed in ways consistent with employment, including assigned schedules and direct work supervision. Many units were not ready to show, and the company faced poor public reviews and limited renter confidence.

The immediate need was to create reliable financial records and stabilize operations. The longer-term opportunity was to return vacant units to productive use, build a stronger reputation, and reinvest rental income into larger renovations.

A phased strategy for property recovery

We walked each building with the maintenance manager, who was also a general contractor and plumber, to evaluate the condition of occupied and vacant units. I helped organize the portfolio into work that could produce near-term rental income and larger projects requiring capital, planning, and longer timelines.

Start with high-impact, affordable improvements

We prioritized vacant units that could become rentable through painting, kitchen or bathroom updates, basic repairs, landscaping, and curb appeal improvements. I photographed finished apartments with my DSLR camera, rebuilt the company website, and used the updated images to market clean, attractive housing. Filling these units brought in revenue that supported the next round of improvements.

Invest where location and rental demand supported the work

One high-priority project was a three-unit converted house near Carnegie Mellon University. Two nearby properties already rented reliably, demonstrating demand for the location. I prepared renovation budgets and cash flow plans, and we arranged financing to move the project forward. The building needed extensive work, including new wiring and reconstruction down to the studs. We renovated one apartment at a time to control spending and return units to service.

The first-floor apartment leased before construction was complete, creating a firm delivery deadline. The second-floor unit followed the same pattern, and the third-floor apartment rented soon after completion. I helped keep the renovation on schedule and within budget while coordinating decisions with Neal and the construction team.

We also renovated a single-family property near UPMC. After the improvements, a physician rented it at approximately four times its prior rental rate.

Creating demand and rebuilding tenant confidence

Targeted marketing, better presentation, and visible progress

I created marketing materials tailored to likely renters, including full-color advertisements placed on student bulletin boards near Carnegie Mellon and the University of Pittsburgh and in their online publications. We shared renovation progress and completed projects through social media, documenting the investment in safer, better-maintained housing. This generated interest before some apartments were ready and helped counter the company's earlier negative reputation.

I encouraged satisfied tenants to leave reviews and built relationships through responsive communication. I also marketed newly improved units to existing residents whose needs had changed. Sometimes a first-year rent discount encouraged a move to a renovated property, opening an older apartment for refurbishment. The strategy helped us upgrade buildings over time without treating existing tenants as obstacles.

Stronger leases and applicant screening

I revised rental agreements to strengthen the terms and clarify expectations. I also implemented more consistent application and screening practices that considered rental history, credit history, and references. The goal was not simply to fill vacancies, but to establish stable tenancies and reduce preventable collection and property-management problems.

Building the operational foundation

Financial systems, reporting, and decision support

My first assignment was to implement QuickBooks, a requirement from the accountant before the firm would take on NBAC's tax work. I established the chart of accounts, organized records for renters, employees, and vendors, and used QuickBooks for payroll. I replaced the original rent spreadsheet with more comprehensive portfolio tracking, then as revenue increased, implemented Buildium as a tenant and property management portal for leases, payments, maintenance requests, and communications.

I prepared project budgets, cash flow projections, and business plans, approved expenses within my responsibilities, and negotiated pricing with contractors. Neal and I discussed financial concerns, priorities, and investment decisions as partners.

Employment practices, staffing, and workplace safety

I identified weaknesses in employment records and worker classification, including contractors who were assigned regular work hours and directed like employees. I helped move the business toward properly documented employment and contractor arrangements, established policies and personnel processes, and supported the growth of the workforce from two employees to approximately 20, with additional specialty contractors engaged as needed.

I also implemented clearer work expectations, employee training, and safety procedures. NBAC had experienced costly workers' compensation claims before I joined. During my tenure there were no workers' compensation claims, and insurance costs decreased after the second annual audit. Over the same period, there was one retirement and one termination.

Strategic asset decisions and financial resilience

Not every property needed to remain in the portfolio. We sold a home to a long-term tenant who wanted to purchase it. We also sold a single-family property in the South Hills that generated relatively little rent and required unusually long travel for maintenance. The sales helped strengthen cash reserves and reduced the need to depend on loans during potential financial downturns.

Our property improvements were also staged around existing tenancies. Two homes with long-term residents remained unchanged when I left; the other retained properties had received updates, renovations, or full remodels. This was a deliberate balance between property standards, available capital, and tenant relationships.

Adapting the rental strategy during COVID

When universities sent students home during COVID, cancellations and vacancies created a serious threat to rental income. Some tenants were facing financial hardship, and in selected cases we released them from leases rather than pursue amounts unlikely to be collected. I recognized a different source of demand nearby: UPMC and other healthcare employers needed traveling nurses and physicians.

I developed a strategy to market suitable units to traveling healthcare professionals through short-term rental arrangements. This helped us keep apartments in use and respond to market conditions rather than rely on the student leasing cycle alone. Neal highlighted this initiative in his May 2021 recommendation letter.

Business impact and leadership

The turnaround was built through a series of connected decisions: first establishing trustworthy financial records, then restoring marketable inventory, creating demand, strengthening employment and leasing practices, and making investments supported by rental performance. We reached a 100% increase in actual rent collected by the end of 2019. By my departure in April 2021, all retained units were rented under annual leases.

In his May 1, 2021 recommendation letter, Neal described the company as worth three times its earlier value and credited my work with rebuilding its foundation. He specifically recognized the QuickBooks implementation, website and marketing materials, company procedures, redevelopment budgeting, COVID rental strategy, and tenant portal. His account reflects the breadth of the work and the trust he placed in me beyond the Office Manager title.

Neal provided the vision and continued to make decisions as owner. The maintenance manager, employees, and contractors carried out critical property work. My contribution was connecting the strategy to financial plans, systems, operations, marketing, and everyday execution so the business could grow without losing sight of property quality and tenant experience.

Capabilities demonstrated

Business turnaround planning; financial management and forecasting; property and asset strategy; redevelopment budgeting; contractor coordination and negotiation; revenue growth; tenant acquisition and retention; digital marketing; accounting and property-management system implementation; employment compliance; workplace safety; and cross-functional operational leadership.